FROM HITLER'S INVASION of the Soviet Union in June 1941 to the conquest of Berlin in May 1945, the soldiers of the Soviet Red Army fought a titanic struggle against Nazi Germany, enduring the heaviest losses ever seen in the history of warfare; over eight million Soviet soldiers were killed. That this struggle should have ended in victory for the Soviet Union was in large part due to the performance of its tank crews, whose T-34s took on and eventually beat the formidable German panzers.



"To Berlin!"
The goal of the Soviet army's long counter-offensive against Germany is emblazoned on the side of a T-34 tank *(above)*. The T-34, the most effective tank of the war, was armed with an 85mm turret gun *(shells right)* and two 7.62mm DT machine-guns.

Adolf Hitler intended his invasion of the Soviet Union to produce a swift and spectacular "blitzkrieg" victory over opponents he despised, both on racial grounds because they were Slavs and on political grounds because they were communists. At first the course of the fighting seemed to fulfil the German dictator's expectation. In a string of military disasters, the poorly led Red Army lost millions of men, killed or taken prisoner, and was driven back to the outskirts of Moscow. But even while inflicting defeat after defeat upon their enemy, the Germans were struck by the extraordinary fighting spirit and almost fatalistic readiness for self-sacrifice exhibited by Soviet troops. This was true not only of the infantry but also of Soviet armoured forces, which were decimated by their experienced German opponents. "Crews in burning tanks kept up fire for as long as there was any breath in their bodies," one German officer wrote.



Excellent Tanker badge
This badge was awarded to crewmen who distinguished themselves in battle. A Soviet tank is depicted.

THE T-34 ENTERS THE SCENE

It was in the midst of this military catastrophe that, in autumn 1941, the T-34 tank made its first appearance on the battlefield. It was a roughly finished, noisy machine that made no concessions to the comfort of its four-man crew. The driver, seated at the front with the tank's machine-gunner alongside him, could only see directly forward and steered mostly on instructions shouted by the tank commander into an intercom. Sitting with the loader in the turret, the commander himself lacked all-round vision. In combat he aimed the gun with his face pressed to the rubber eye guard of his sight, while the loader fetched the ammunition to his orders. This was no simple task, as most of the rounds were stored in bins under the rubber matting of the turret floor. The scene in the turret was often chaotic, with commander and loader dodging the recoil of the gun while hot shell cases flew into a half-dismantled tangle of shell bins and matting. Inevitably, inexperienced commanders tended to lose all sense of the battlefield situation around them, especially as none of the tanks had radios.

Yet tank crews quickly found much to praise about the T-34. It was a rugged and reliable fighting machine capable of travelling over ice or boggy ground that would stop other tanks dead. It was also quick and nimble: a German tank sergeant commented that "the Russian tanks … will climb a slope or cross a piece of swamp faster than you can traverse the turret."



85MM TANK SHELLS